M365 FOR RESEARCH

Laura Standaert / Koen Verstraeten / 04-12-2025

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WHO IS WHO?

- Koen Verstraeten
  - IT Information Manager @Functional Domain ICT
  - Trainer SharePoint Online and M365 Tools
  - M365 Community manager

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WHO IS WHO?

- Laura Standaert
  - Data steward Life Sciences
  - Providing support for Research Data Management
  - Open Science team at the University library

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M365: USING RDM WORKSPACES FOR RESEARCH DATA

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https://osf.io/57gvr/files/eq8s4

OUTLINE

- Storage during research projects
- OneDrive? SharePoint? Teams? M365!
- SharePoint templated structure: RDM workspace
- Getting started
- Examples
- Highlighted SharePoint features
- Wrap-up
- Q&A

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BEST PRACTICE

Research projects require a place where **data and documentation** resulting from the research project are **safely stored**, and **information can be exchanged** between project team members and external collaborators

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UGENT POLICIES

- UGent RDM policy framework: make and keep data understandable and reusable

- Valorisation: document findings to substantiate contractual obligations and prove inventorship
  - > May require audit trailing and logging: Electronic Lab Notebook RSpace
    (not in scope of this session)
- Confidentiality of data (classification of data)
  - Because of valorisation potential, contracts, ethics, the nature of the data, …
  - Indicate access restrictions and enforce these

- Overview of the Framework for Good Research Practice:
  https://www.ugent.be/en/research/framework

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STORAGE DURING PROJECTS

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BEST PRACTICES: UGENT STORAGE PLATFORMS

Where to store research data during projects?

1. Project Share: network storage
   → share with promotor
   → work directly on the shares
   → not for Bachelor/Master students

2. SharePoint / Teams
   → share with promotor

! Avoid local storage (only)
! Avoid external cloud providers (Google Drive, Dropbox, …)
If you have to **=> Encryption!**

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https://helpdesk.ugent.be/security/en/veilig-werken-medewerkers.php
https://www.ugent.be/en/research/openscience/datamanagement/during-research/storage.htm

NETWORK STORAGE @ UGENT

Storage on server hosted by ICT, inside UGent

- Accessed via UGent network
- Shared (aka "Project shares", “the share”, S:/shares/*)
- Long term storage
- Large datasets
- Back-up using snapshots



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M365 AND SHAREPOINT

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MICROSOFT 365



Microsoft platform of (online) applications for

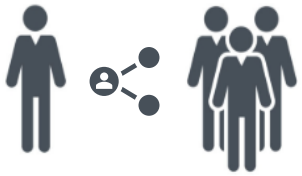
- Documents, spreadsheets, presentations, …
- Communication: email, chat, online meetings, …
- Storage ‘in the cloud’: for yourself, or shared

WHAT TO CHOOSE?

Personal working environment

- Personal storage location of documents, video's, …
- 1TB storage for every student and employee
- Share ad hoc individual documents with colleagues or external collaborators
- Disappears when you leave UGent

OneDrive for Work or School



Collaborate as a Team

- Flexibel information sharing, online meetings, chat, …
- For a project, as a team (department, lab), or for education.
- All members have the same permissions
  - Except private groups: access is controlled by owner
- Has its own SharePoint site

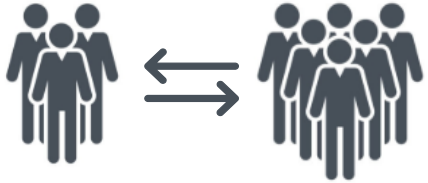
MS Teams Team



Inform, publish, structure

- Structured managment of information by means of lists, libraries and pages
- Flexible, fine grained or advanced permission management
- Can be used for more formal communication or presenting aggregated news

Standalone SharePoint Online



Storage for 1

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MICROSOFT 365: ONEDRIVE FOR WORK OR SCHOOL



- Access via browser: ugentbe-my.sharepoint.com
- Sync to local: accessible anywhere
- Total 1TB. GB OK, TB not OK
- Integration with Office, version history
- For **personal professional use**
- Possible to share BUT long-term availability not guaranteed
- Linked to UGent account
- More info and “how-to”: https://helpdesk.ugent.be/office365/en/onedrivefb.php

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Shared Storage

MICROSOFT 365: SHAREPOINT

- **For sharing, collaborating, joint editing**
- Possible to share externally
- GB OK, TB not OK
- Access control lists
- Integration with Office
- Version history
- Access via browser: ugentbe.sharepoint.com/…
- Add shortcut to OneDrive: accessible anywhere (offline vs. online)

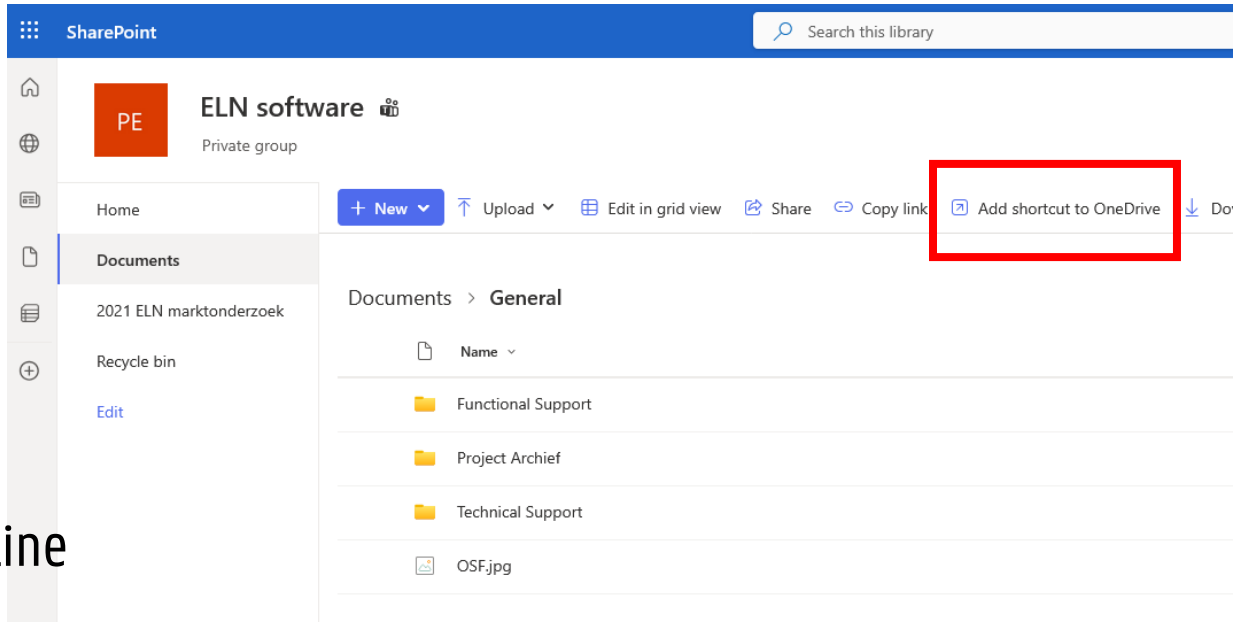
- Either linked to MS Teams team or stand-alone

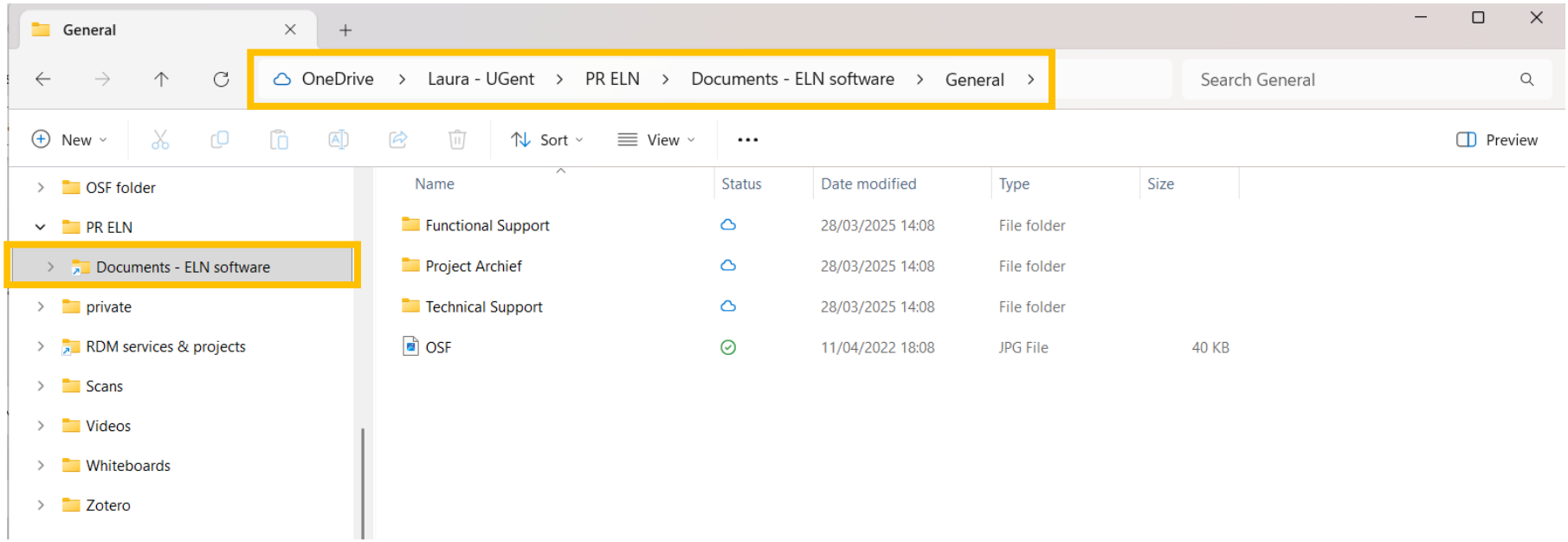
or

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ACCESS TO SHAREPOINT

- Shortcuts to OneDrive
  - Available in File Explorer
  - Your OneDrive folder
  - You can decide which documents you need offline





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INTERCONNECTED M365 APPLICATIONS

Go to: https://www.office.com and sign in with your UGent account

Integrated eco-system of applications in M365 Copilot

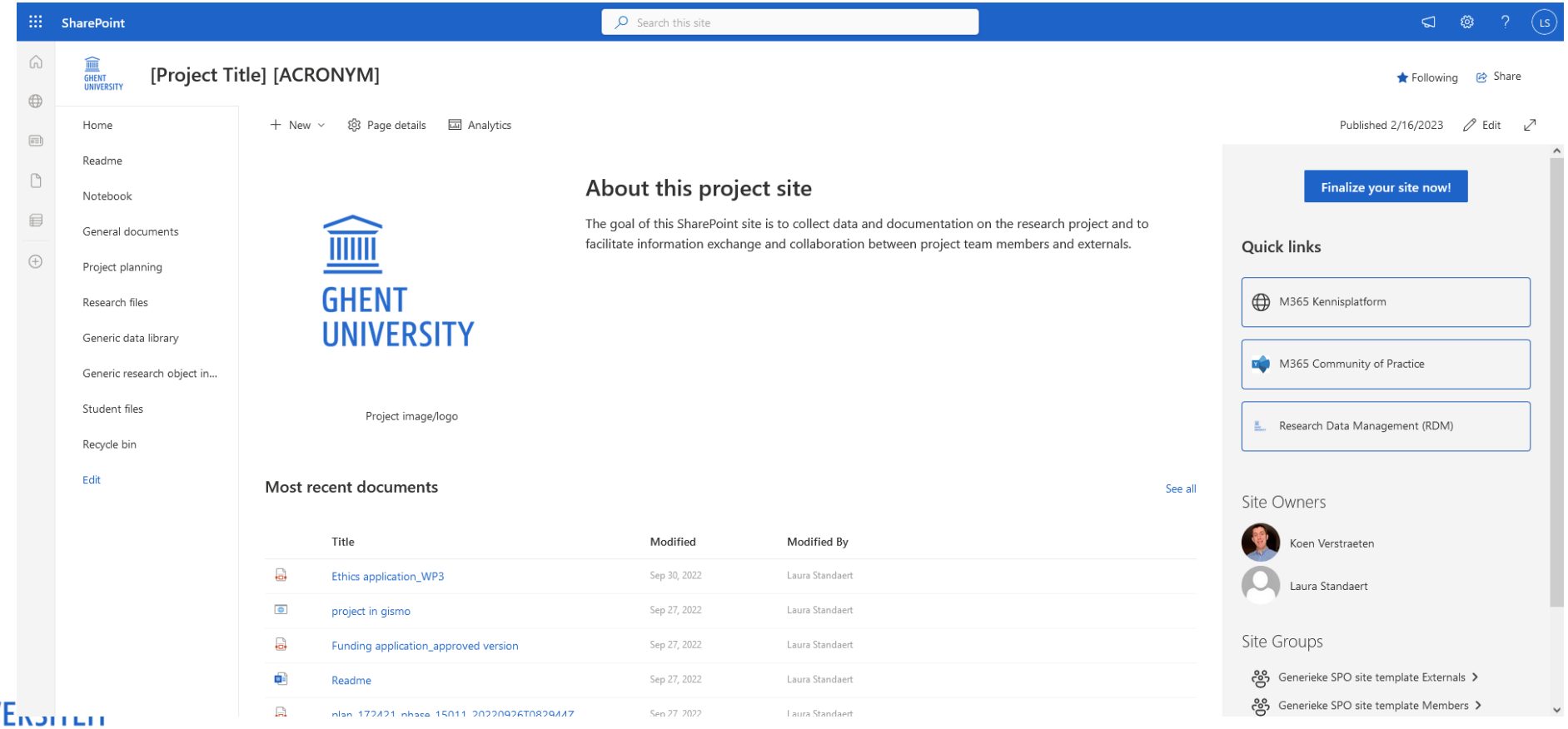


WHAT IS THE RDM WORKSPACE?

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SHAREPOINT TEMPLATE: RDM WORKSPACE

- Designed for a research project, as a workspace for research data management
- Storage organized in libraries and lists
- No Teams attached



Research Data Management (RDM) Workspace

RDM WORKSPACE DEFAULT STRUCTURE

Based on best practices for file and folder organisation in research projects, this template structure has been implemented.

- General documents
  - Administration, Dissemination, Progress reports, Meeting notes, …
- Research files
- Project planning
  - Keep track of milestones
- Data library with linked inventory
- Student files
  - Specific permissions

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GETTING STARTED WITH RDM WORKSPACE

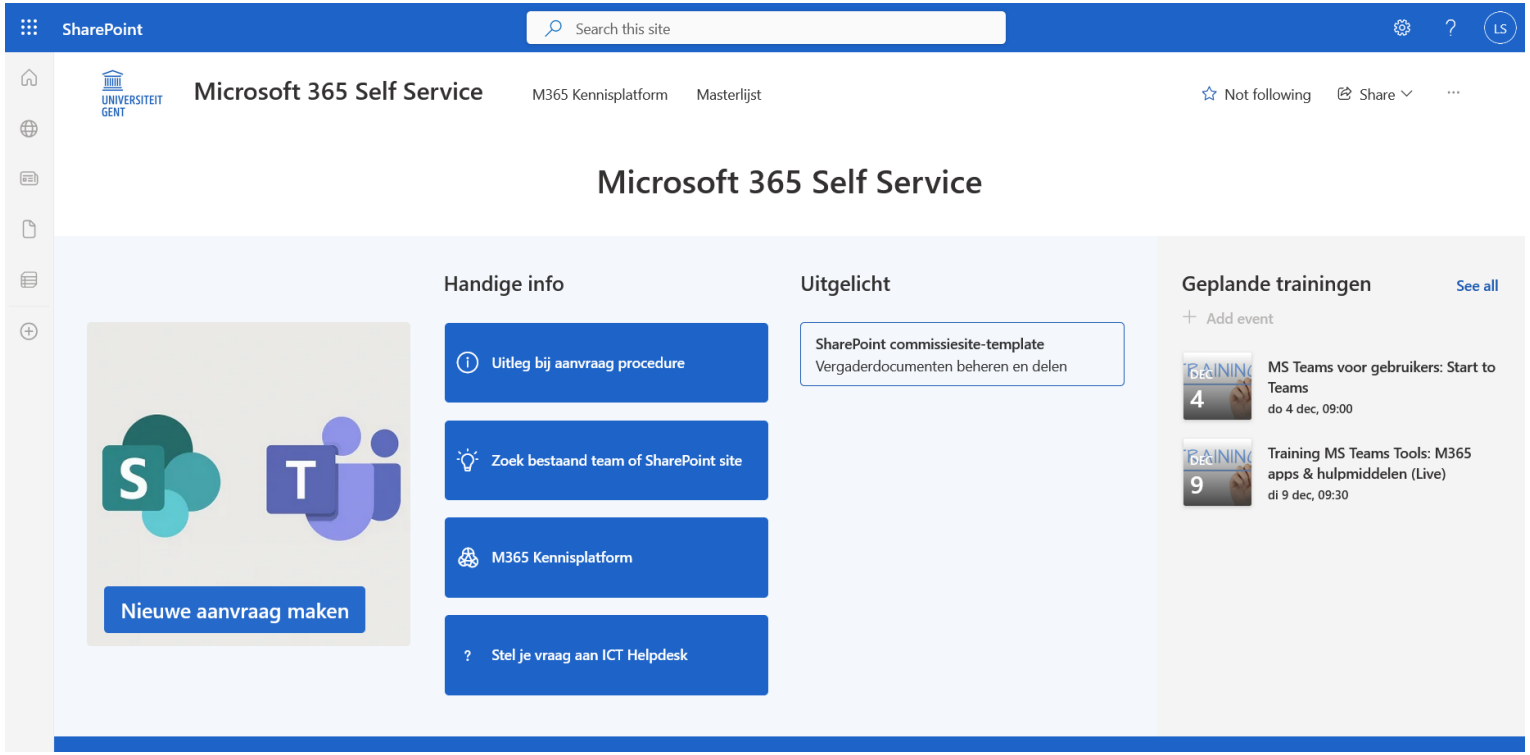
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GETTING STARTED…

Available via M365 Self Service

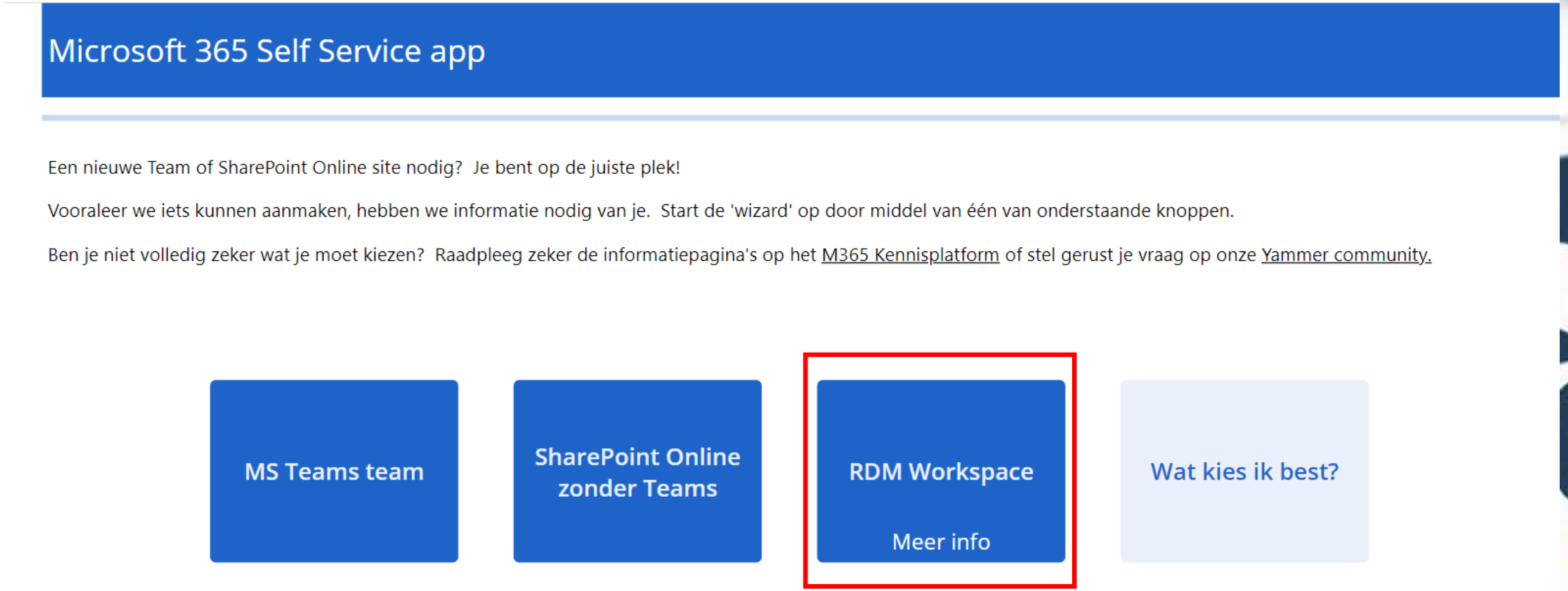
Where you can request Teams and SharePoint-sites

Provide title and indicate the site owners: you and the promoter!



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M365 SELF SERVICE



https://ugentbe.sharepoint.com/sites/selfservice

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M365 SELF SERVICE

Doel van je RDM Workspace

Voor welk doel wil je een RDM Workspace aanvragen? Selecteer het meest geschikte:

Vorige | Volgende

Project

Je gebruikt een RDM Workspace voor een project, PhD, of iets anders waarvoor je een tijdelijke RDM Workspace nodig hebt (bv voorbereiding van een conferentie).

You use a RDM Workspace for a project, PhD, or for another purpose where you need a temporary RDM Workspace (eg to prepare an event). The lifetime of this RDM Workspace is rather limited (not permanent).

Sandbox

Je wilt een RDM Workspace gebruiken om te experimenteren of ervaring op te doen met de verschillende mogelijkheden van RDM Workspace of Microsoft365-platform. Deze RDM Workspace mag steeds verwijderd worden omdat deze geen belangrijke informatie bevat.

You use this RDM Workspace as a playground or to experiment with the many features within RDM Workspace or Microsoft365-platform. This RDM Workspace could be removed at any time because it doesn't contain important information.

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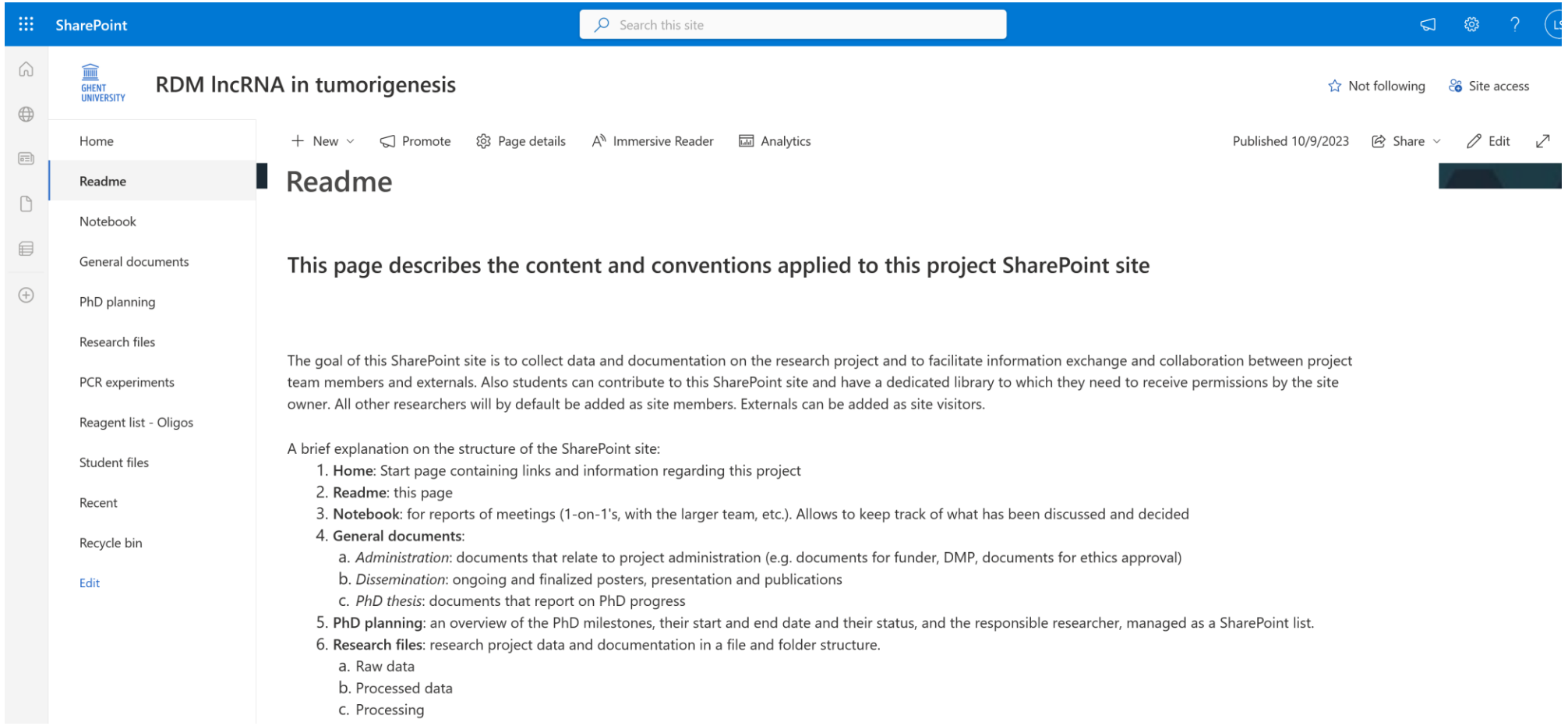
AFTER CREATION OF THE SITE

- ❑ Revise the proposed structure and modify where needed.
- ❑ Give permissions to team members and others involved in the project. Include at least the promoter and investigators working on the project.
- ❑ Record the link to the project SharePoint in a place where you and other team members will easily find it, such as a group overview page.
- ❑ Get started with documenting your research!

AGREE ON STORAGE ORGANISATION

Pro Tip!
Align within your research group

- Discuss and document the approach



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MANAGE WHO CAN DO WHAT: USER GROUPS

Owners

- For owners of the research project SharePoint site
- At least 2, max 3
- Have full control over all content and settings of the RDM Workspace

Members

- For team members or close collaborators within UGent
- Have permission to read and contribute to all content of the RDM Workspace

Externals

- For external collaborators in the project
- Have permission to read and contribute to all content of the RDM Workspace

Visitors

- For informing
- Have read access to all content of the RDM Workspace
- e.g. for your colleagues in your research team

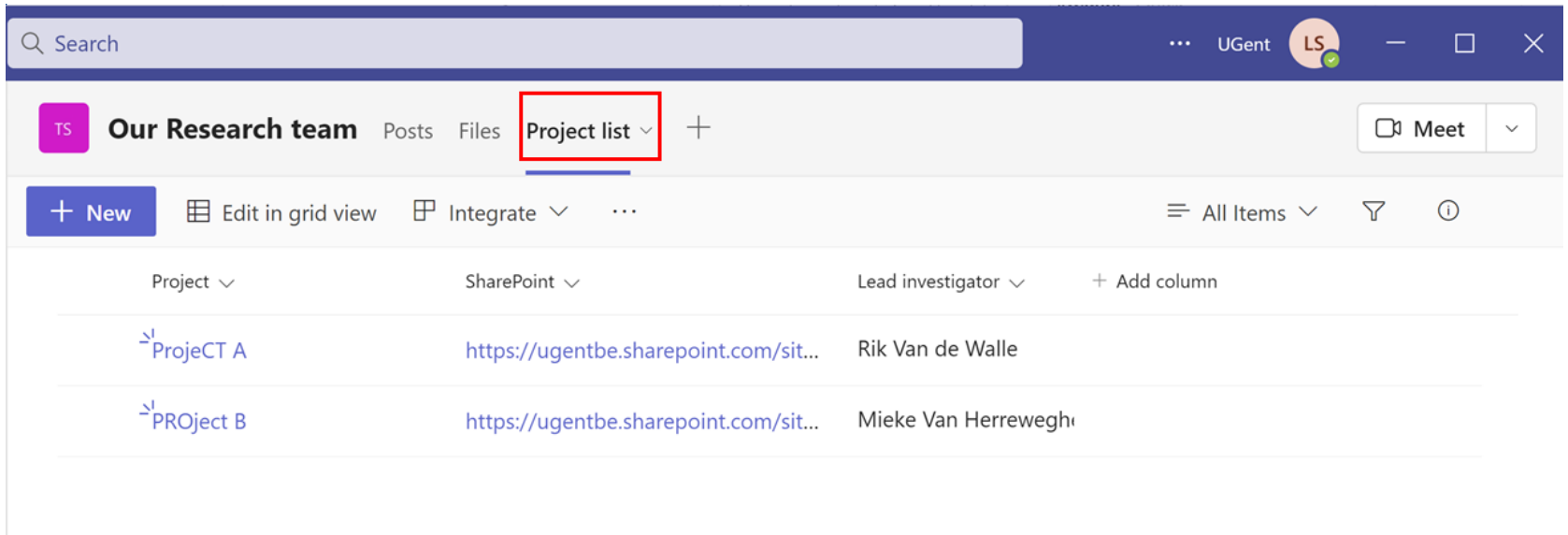
Students

- For Bachelor or Master students
- Have read access to the Home page and can contribute to the Student files library only

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KEEP TRACK OF SHAREPOINT SITES

- https://ugentbe.sharepoint.com/_layouts/15/sharepoint.aspx
- Check all SharePoint sites and Teams at Ghent University (via Self Service): https://ugentbe.sharepoint.com/sites/SelfService/SitePages/Search.aspx
- Record the link to your project site!
  - E.g. in a Teams team of the research group



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EXAMPLES

EXAMPLE SITES

- Example RDM workspace sites
  - Nutrient Recycle RDM workspace
  - Coral Health RDM workspace
  - lncRNA in tumorigenesis RDM workspace

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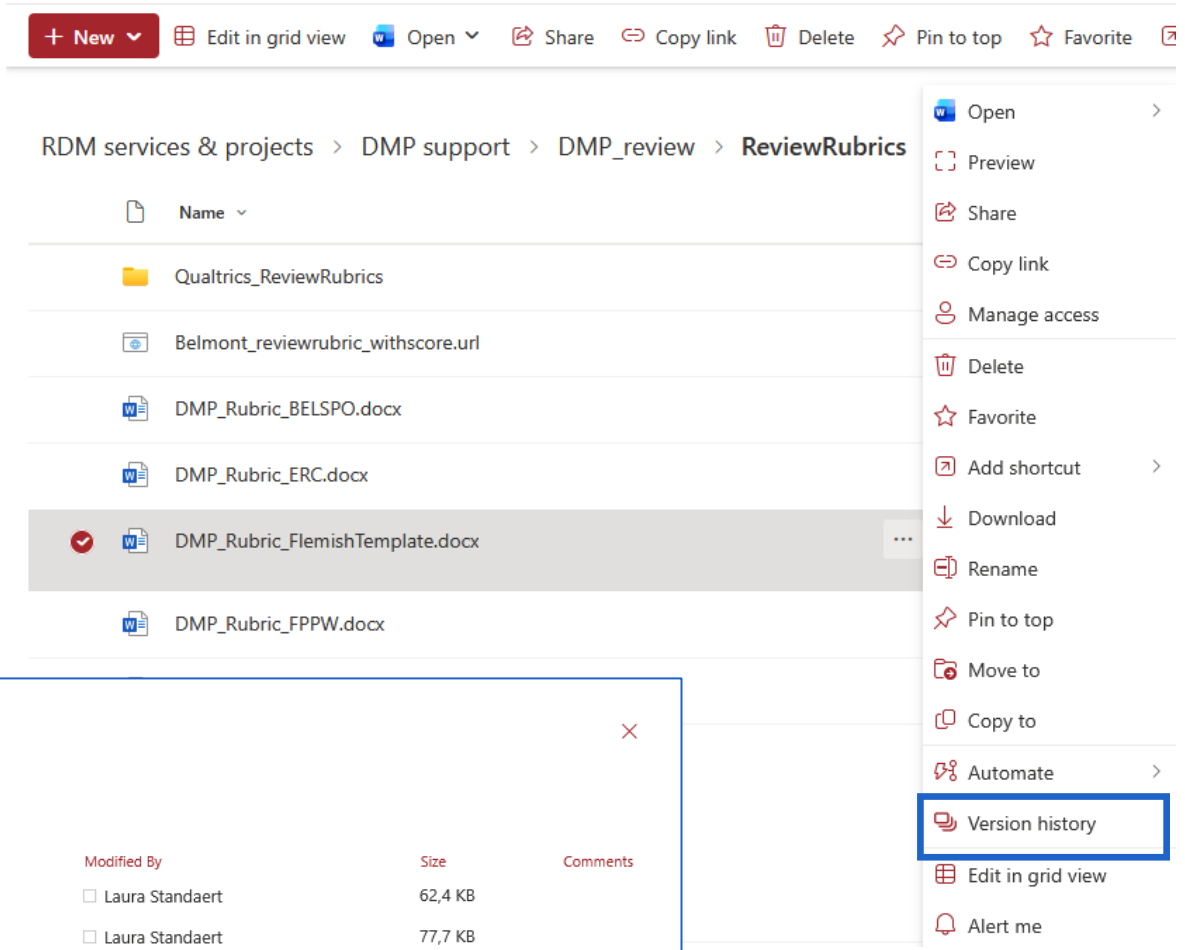
USEFUL FEATURES IN SHAREPOINT

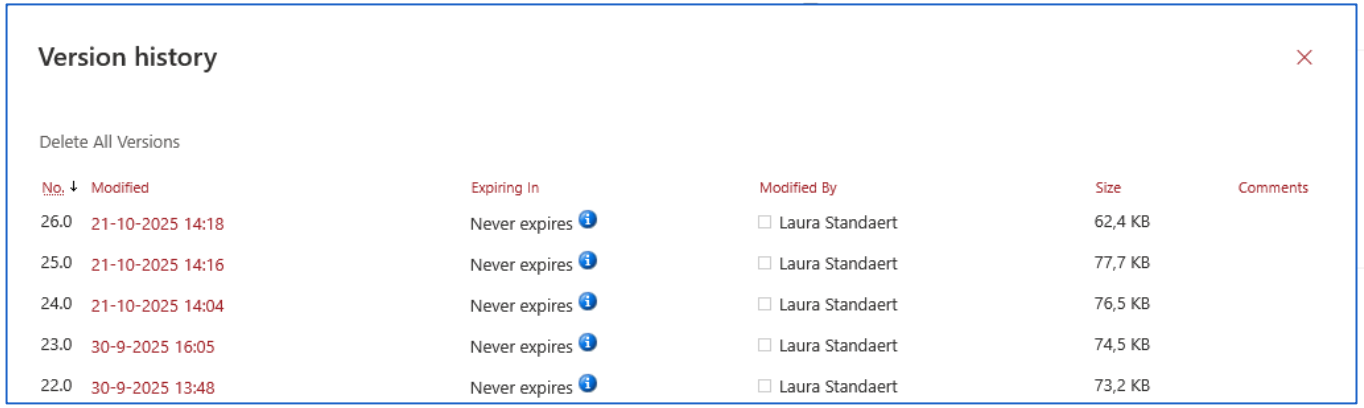
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Versioning

CONSULT VERSION HISTORY

APPROACH 1: ONLINE: 3 DOTS (ELLIPSIS)

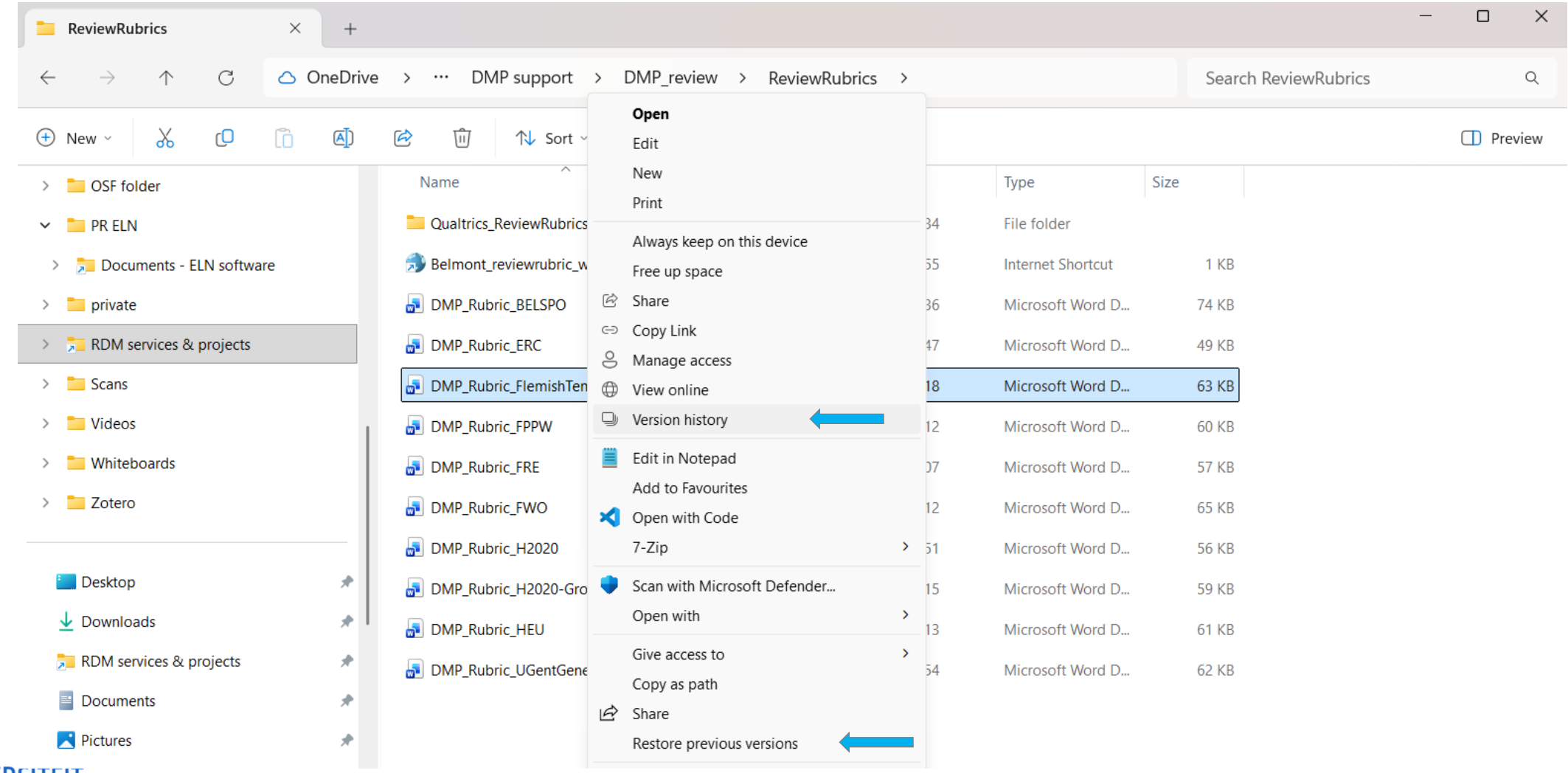




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CONSULT VERSION HISTORY

APPROACH 2: SYNCED FILES IN FILE EXPLORER

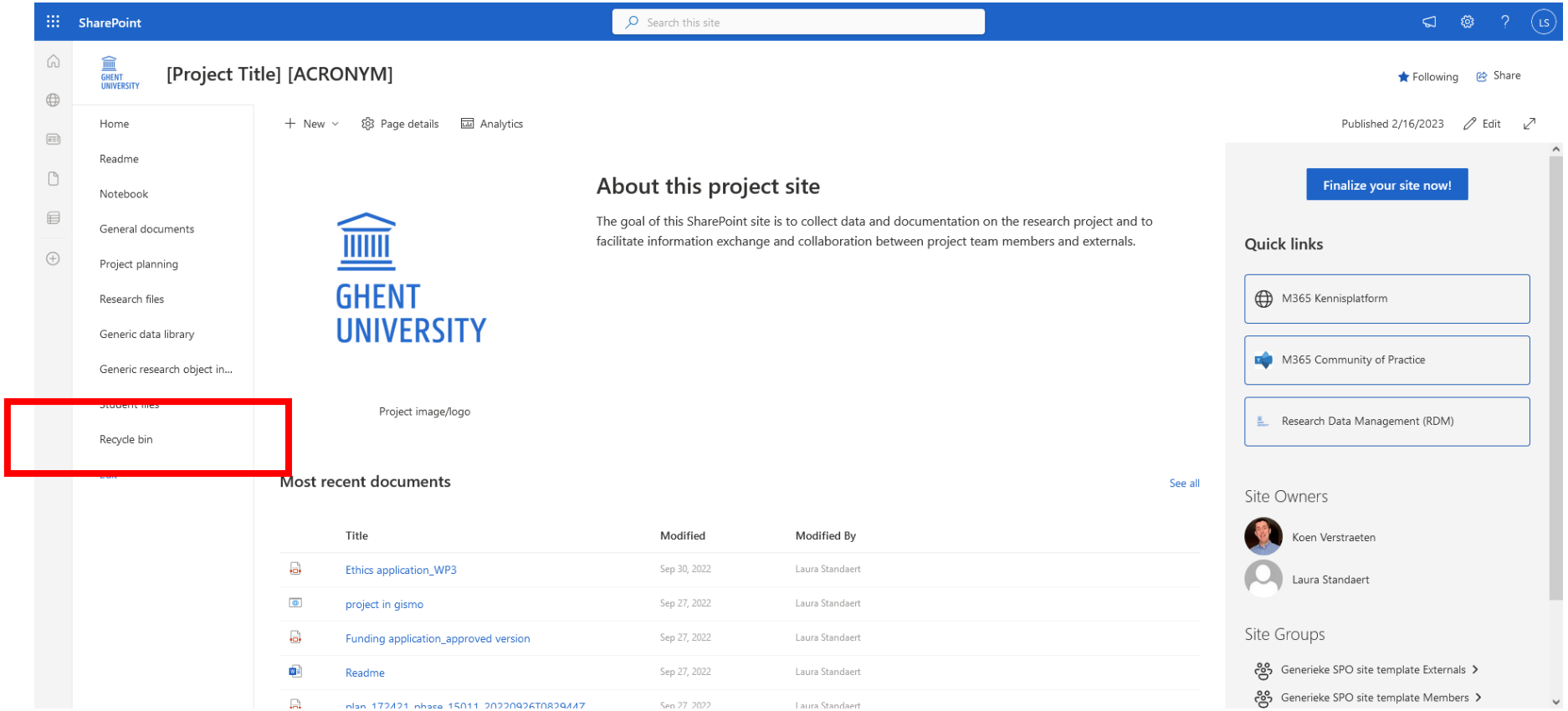


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Retrieving files

RECOVER DELETED FILES

- Accidental deletion of file → recovery for 93 days + 93 days (second stage)
- Site contents > Recycle bin



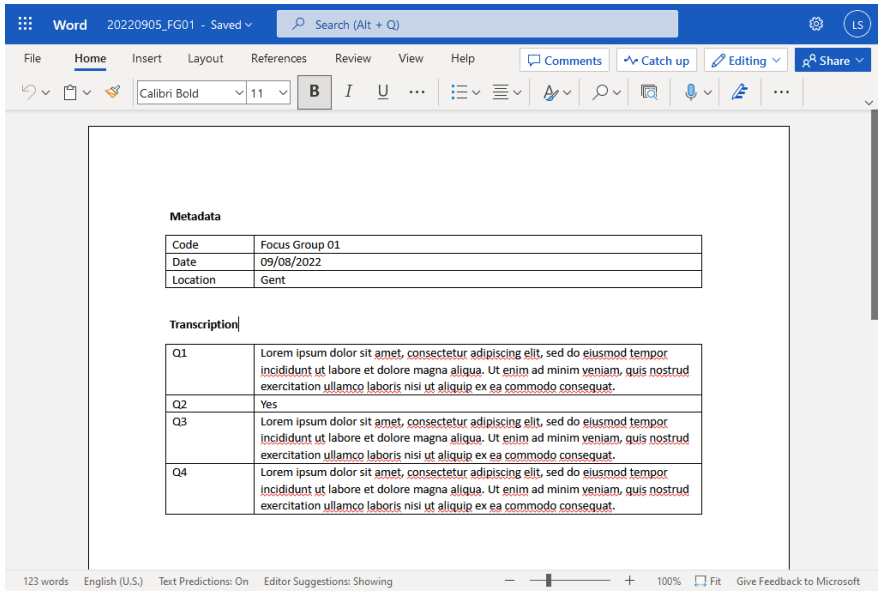
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Efficient collaboration on files

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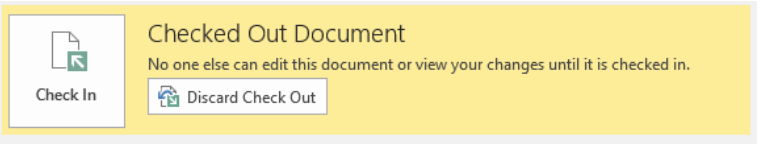
EASIER COLLABORATION

- Option 1:
  - Simultaneously edit documents
    - Works best online
  - Check versions for changes (what, when, who)
  - (Optionally) use track changes and comments



- Option 2:
  - Check-out: I can edit the file, others cannot edit
  - Check-in: everyone can edit the file
  - New version is created and visible after check-in



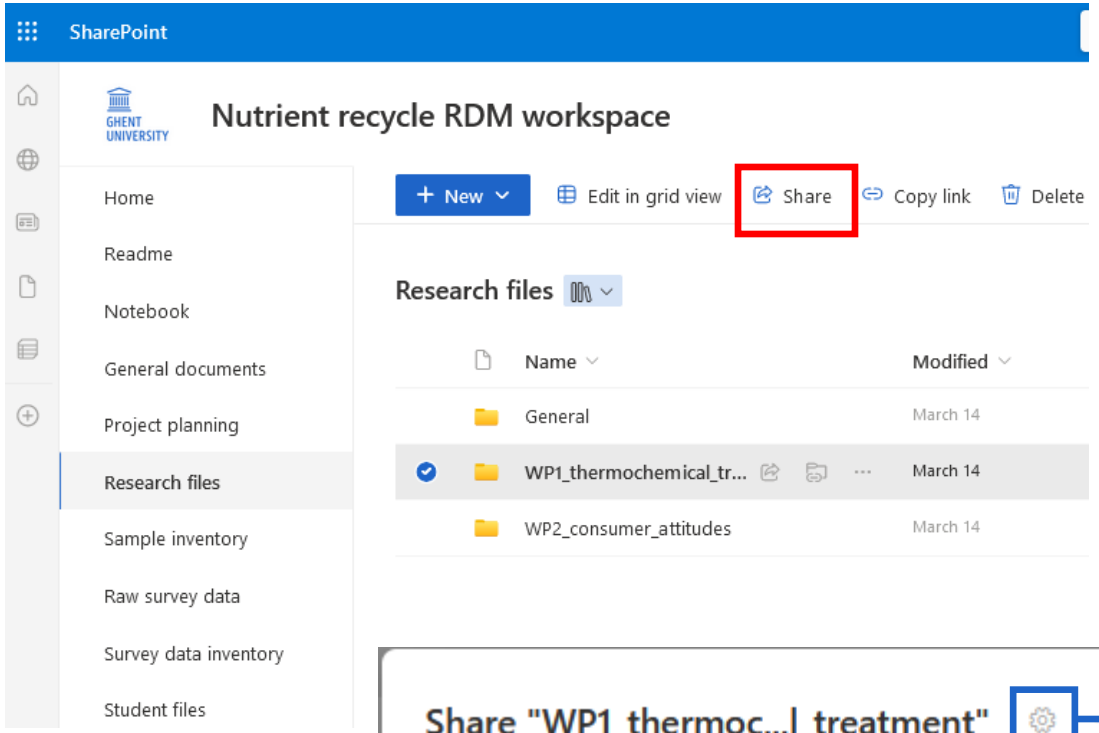


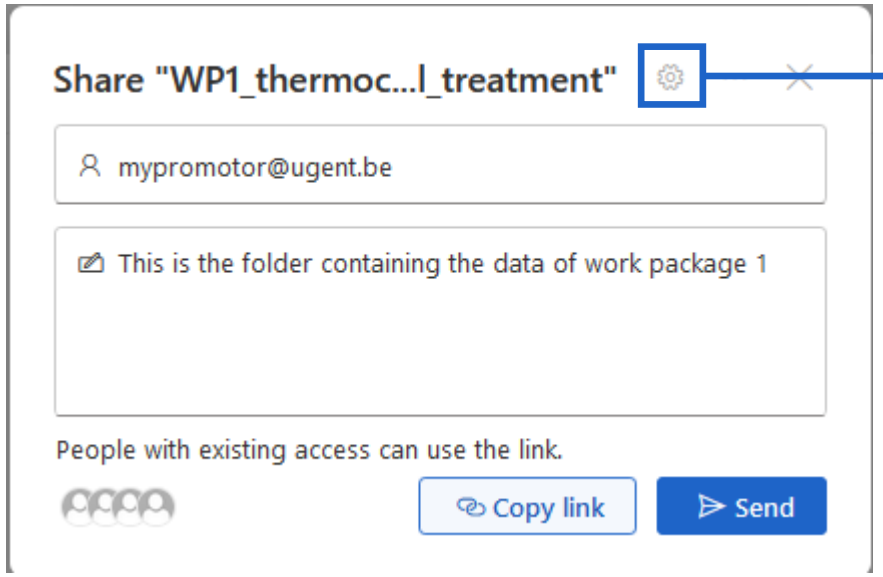
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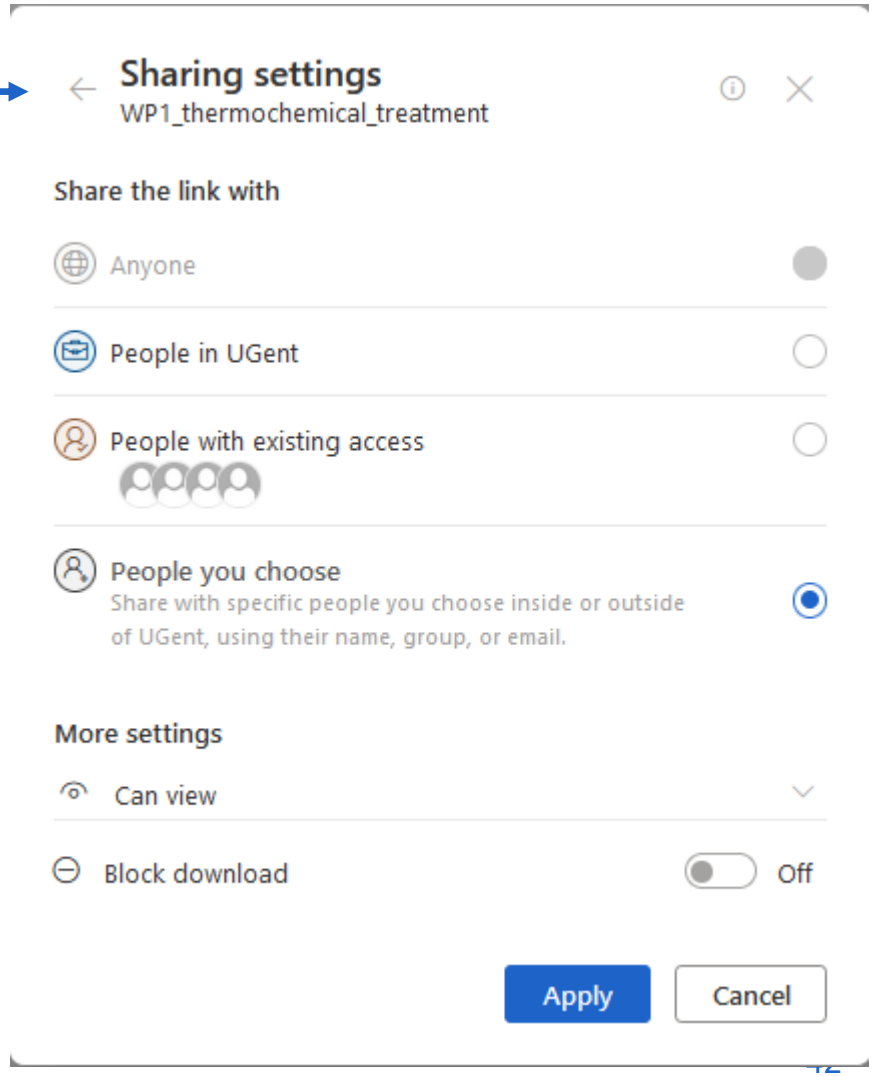
BEST PRACTICES

- Work/collaborate on the same file instead of creating new files upon change
  - Work on online version; stored in a central place
  - Same file name
  - Version history will allow you to retrace the steps
- Share files through SharePoint, Teams (or OneDrive) instead of email
  - i.e. avoid creation of multiple parallel versions
- Use **sharing links** to SharePoint or Teams files or folders to reference or share
  - Beware of sharing permissions
  - ‘People with existing access’ by default

SHARING A FILE OR FOLDER FROM SHAREPOINT

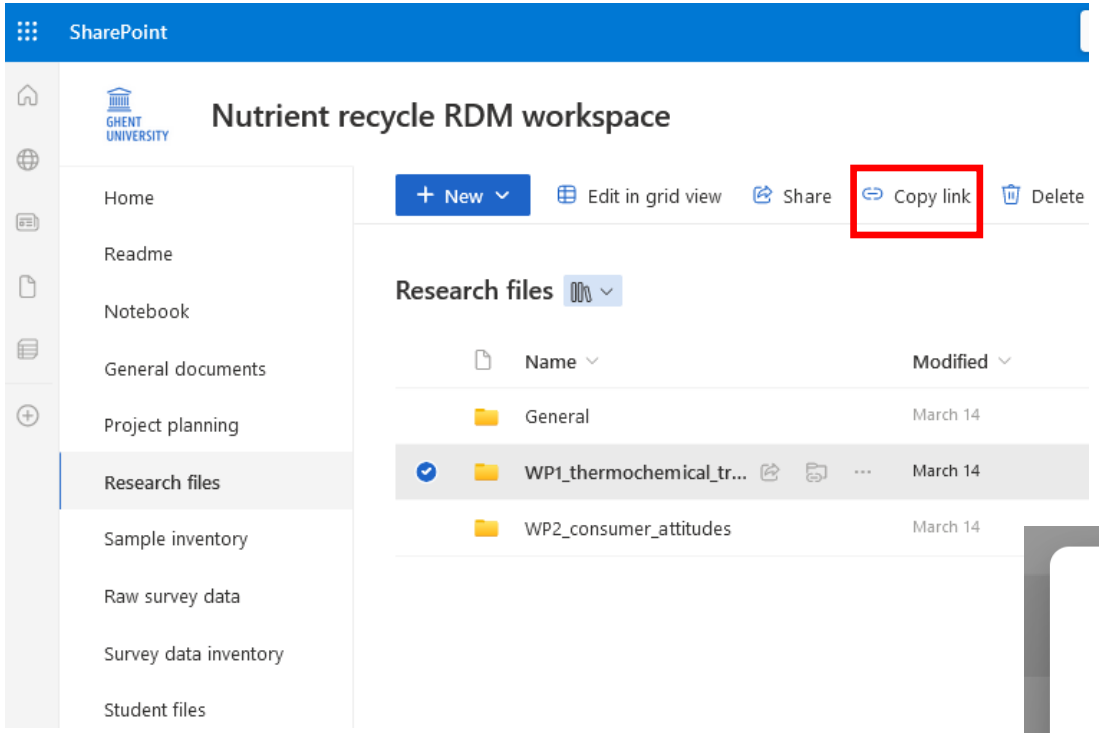


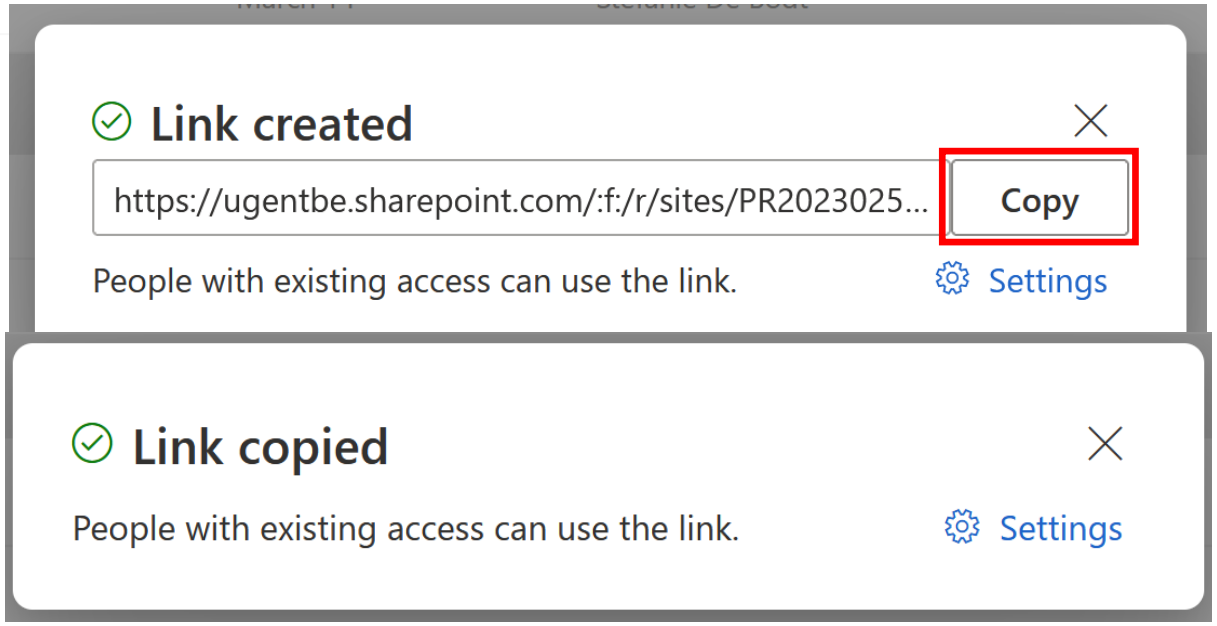




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COPYING A LINK TO A FILE OR FOLDER FROM SHAREPOINT

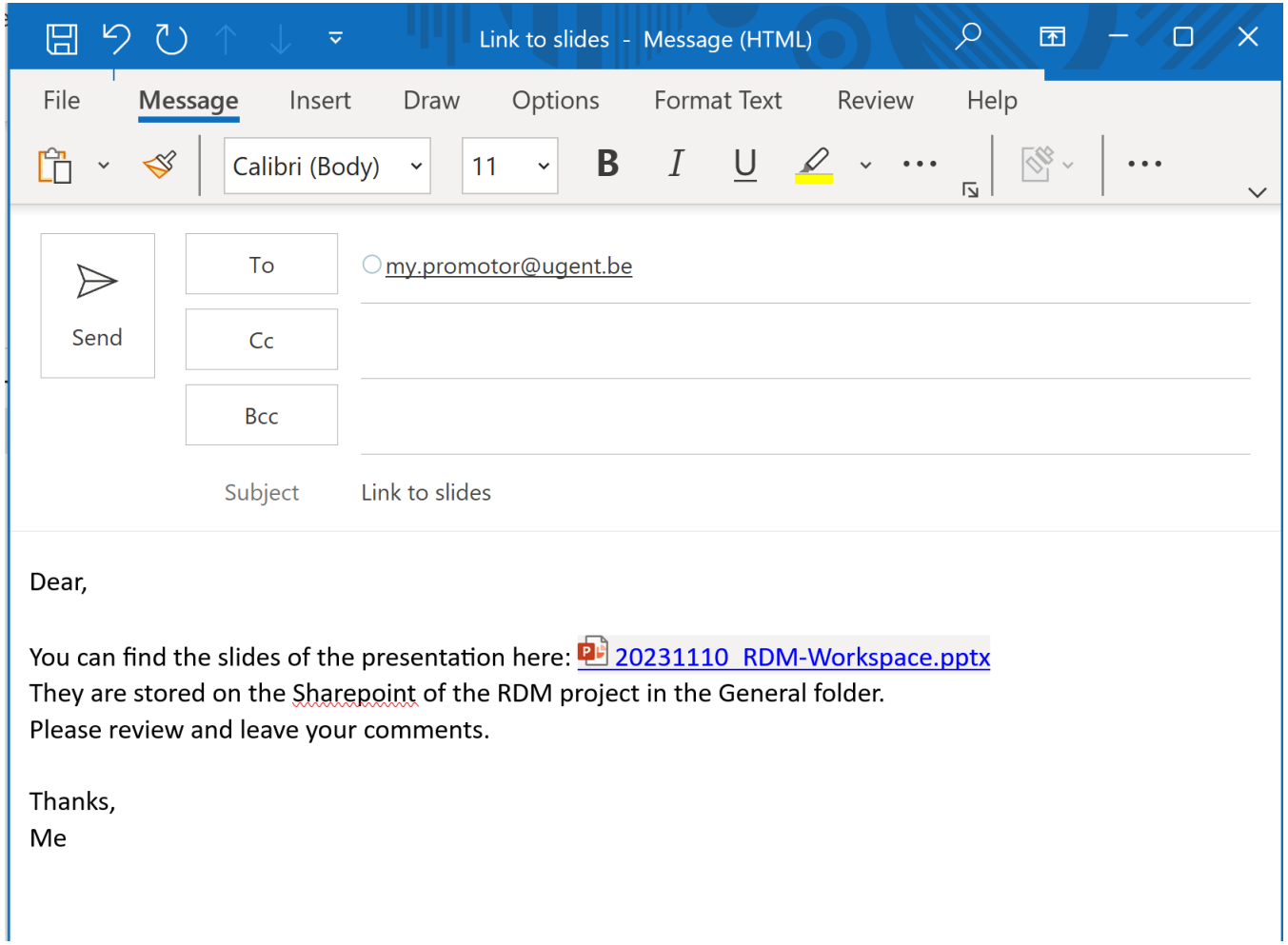




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ASKING TO REVIEW A FILE ON A PROJECT SHAREPOINT

- Add the link to the file in an email or other type of message



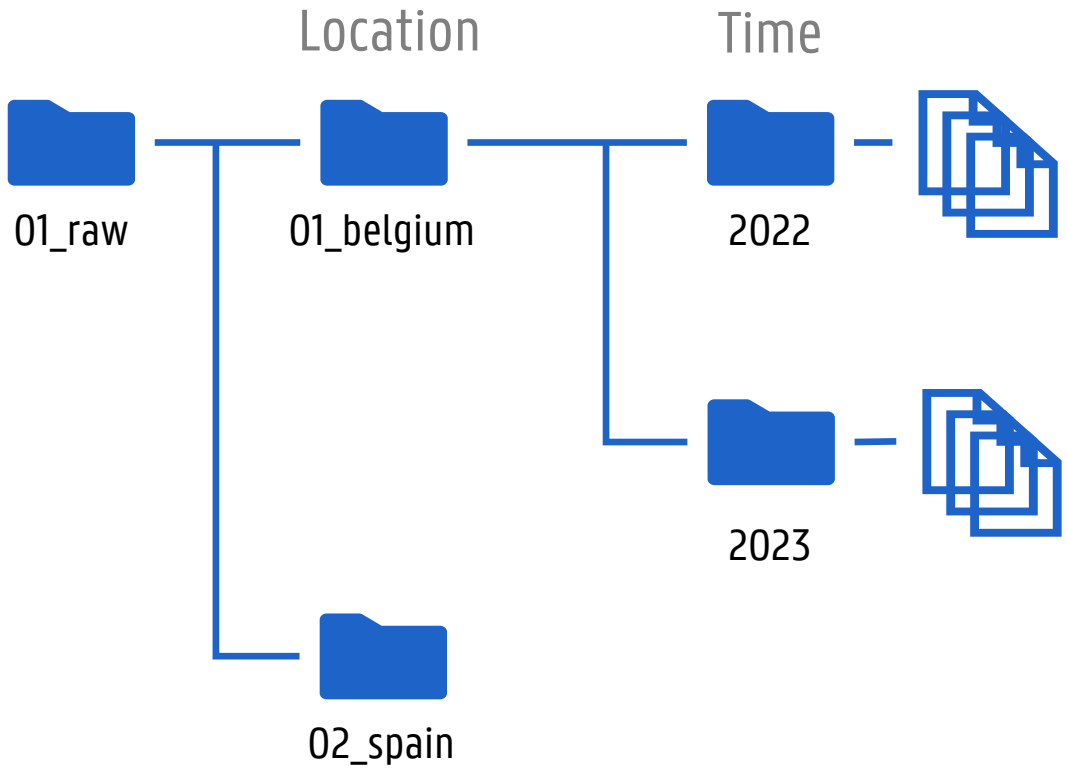
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File or item metadata

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FILE ORGANISATION AND DOCUMENTATION

FOLDERS



Examples:

Folder hierarchy on project share

Library and subfolders on SharePoint site

METADATA



Location	Time
Belgium	2022
Belgium	2023
Belgium, Spain	2023
Spain	2022
Spain	2023

Examples:

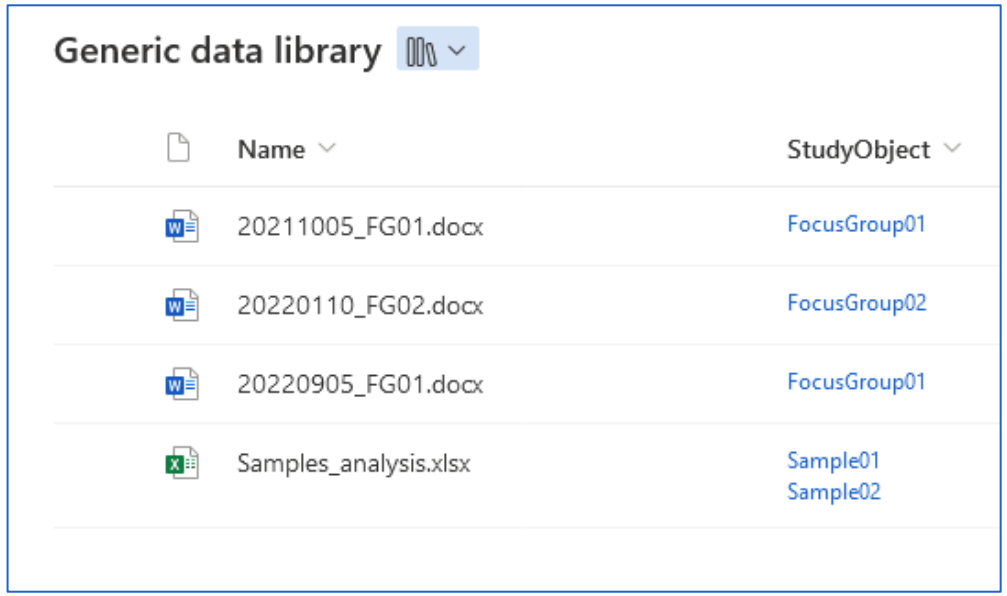
Library on SharePoint site

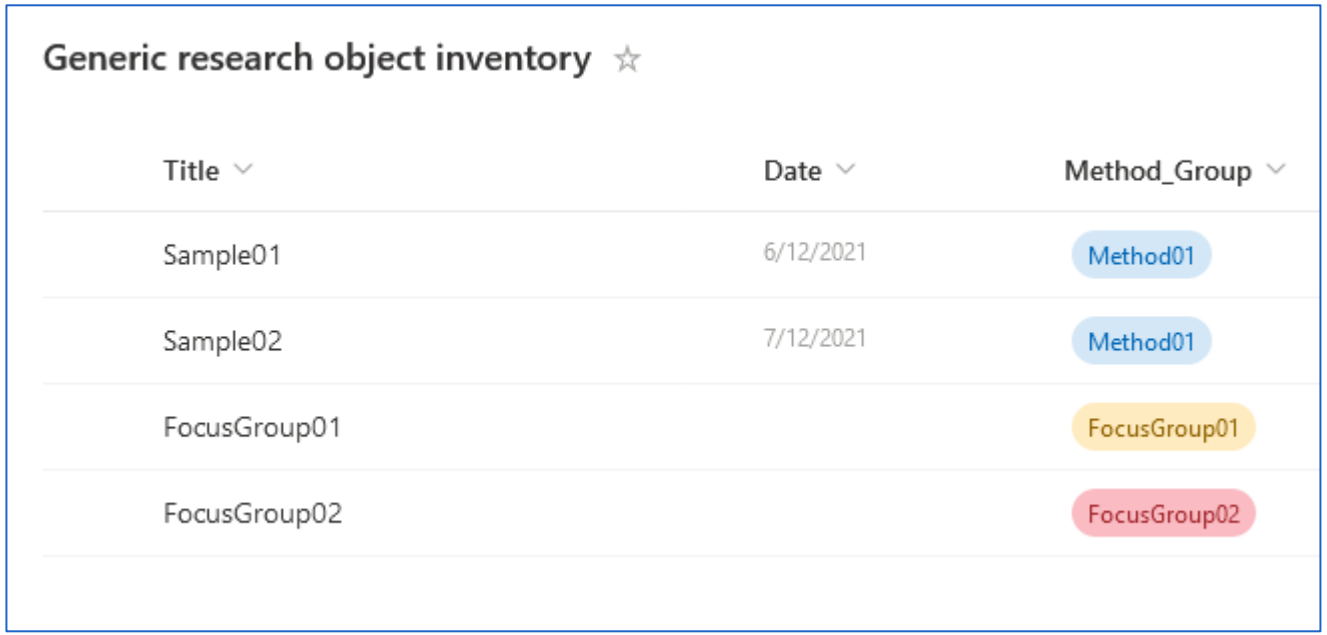
List on SharePoint site

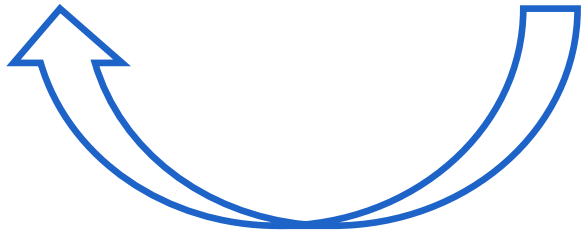
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RDM WORKSPACE: DATA LIBRARY AND LINKED INVENTORY

- Take advantage of metadata fields
- Organize files in the library and build an inventory of research objects in a list







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WRAP-UP

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MANAGING THE INFORMATION YOU COLLECT DURING A RESEARCH PROJECT

- Research projects require a place where data and documentation on the research project is collected, and information can be exchanged between project team members and external collaborators
- SharePoint is a platform where this is possible
  - Researchers can create new libraries, lists and content to document the research project
  - Accessible within the M365 platform

- (!) Check with your supervisor if a structure has already been created for your group or project.

UGent Data Stewards / ICT

FUNCTIONAL DOMAIN RESEARCH - UNIVERSITY LIBRARY

FUNCTIONAL DOMAIN ICT



rdm.support@ugent.be

https://helpdesk.ugent.be/helpme



ugent.be/en/research/datamanagement

https://helpdesk.ugent.be

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TRAINING AND RESOURCES

- If you want to communicate to team members, post in channels and chat, a SharePoint site linked to an MS Teams team is the best choice.
- UGent offers several trainings on MS Teams and SharePoint
- There is a Community of Practice M365
- Check out these videos.

MORE RESOURCES

- DICT course material
  - Overview
  - ICT at Ugent
  - Microsoft Teams
- OneDrive for Business
  - DICT helpdesk on OneDrive
- Project shares
  - Requesting a project share
  - Mounting network drives
  - Retrieving snapshots
- IT security
  - Encryption guidelines
  - UGent security guidelines

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